

Resume: Russ Weakley

Digital Accessibility Specialist

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Profile

I'm a Digital Accessibility Specialist with extensive experience across accessibility, front-end development, UX, design systems, inclusive research and training. I have worked with major organisations in banking and insurance, helping teams test, build and improve accessible digital products and complex interfaces.

My experience includes accessibility auditing and remediation, accessibility strategy and governance, assistive technology testing, inclusive research with people with disabilities, developer support, and organisational capability development.

I combine deep technical accessibility knowledge with practical experience helping designers, developers, testers and product teams understand accessibility barriers and implement effective solutions.

I have also worked directly with people with disabilities for more than 20 years through usability testing, interviews, focus groups and research conducted in homes and workplaces, helping ensure accessibility decisions are informed by lived experience.

Core expertise

Accessibility testing and remediation

Extensive experience conducting accessibility audits, reviews and assessments, including manual and automated testing, WCAG interpretation, root-cause analysis, remediation guidance and integration of accessibility into QA and development workflows.

Assistive technologies and technical accessibility

Extensive testing with NVDA, JAWS and VoiceOver, along with screen magnification, speech recognition, voice control, keyboard-only and alternative input methods. Deep understanding of HTML, ARIA, browser accessibility trees, platform accessibility APIs and cross-browser assistive technology behaviour.

Accessibility strategy, governance and compliance

Accessibility strategy, governance, organisational capability development, accessibility acceptance criteria, compliance planning and embedding accessibility into product and delivery workflows.

Inclusive research and user testing

More than 20 years of inclusive research experience, including usability testing, heuristic evaluation, focus groups, interviews, contextual inquiry and direct collaboration with people with disabilities.

Training and capability development

More than 20 years delivering accessibility and technical training, including large-scale organisational programs, developer training, assistive technology training, curriculum development and instructor-led and self-paced learning.

Design systems and inclusive design

Design system strategy, architecture, governance and accessibility integration, including translating accessibility requirements into reusable components and patterns that can improve accessibility at scale.

Professional experience

Head of Inclusive Training: Intopia

Nov 2021 – Present

Lead the strategy, planning and delivery of Intopia's accessibility education ecosystem, helping organisations build practical accessibility capability across product, design, development, testing and content teams.

Key responsibilities

- Lead accessibility learning and capability strategies for organisations and teams.

- Develop organisational training strategies based on current levels of accessibility skill, knowledge and understanding.
- Use skills and knowledge surveys to identify capability gaps and shape training programs.
- Develop pre-training engagement strategies to increase awareness, participation and organisational support.
- Plan post-training follow-up activities to reinforce learning and help teams apply accessibility in day-to-day work.
- Oversee the full training lifecycle, from identifying learning needs and developing concepts through to curriculum design, scripting, exercises, production, delivery and evaluation.
- Design and deliver accessibility learning for developers, designers, testers, content creators, accessibility specialists and organisational leaders.
- Lead development across instructor-led and self-paced training formats.
- Translate WCAG, HTML, ARIA, assistive technology behaviour and complex accessibility concepts into practical guidance.
- Deliver practical accessibility testing training, including NVDA and VoiceOver.
- Design and deliver training on conducting user research with people with disability, including interaction with people with lived experience.
- Develop hands-on accessibility exercises, test pages and supporting resources used by auditors, QA teams and other accessibility practitioners.
- Partner with organisations to embed accessibility knowledge and capability across roles and teams.
- Support organisations in moving from one-off accessibility awareness activities to sustained capability development.

Accessibility Principal: IAG (Insurance Australia Group)

Feb 2021 – Nov 2021

Led accessibility strategy, compliance, testing and capability initiatives to help teams deliver more accessible digital products and customer experiences.

Key responsibilities

- Supported sprint teams with hands-on troubleshooting and remediation of accessibility issues during design and development.
- Conducted 20 full accessibility audits across 20 digital products, identifying barriers and providing practical remediation guidance.
- Introduced automated accessibility testing tools into development pipelines so teams could identify issues earlier in delivery.
- Delivered accessibility awareness sessions across the organisation, including sessions for senior leaders and executives.
- Delivered accessibility training for developers across 12 product squads.

- Provided specialist accessibility guidance to product, design, development and QA teams.
- Supported accessibility compliance and the practical application of WCAG requirements.
- Helped teams understand and use accessibility acceptance criteria throughout design, development and testing.
- Helped embed accessibility into development practices, delivery workflows and organisational ways of working.

Design System Principal: IAG (Insurance Australia Group)

Mar 2018 – Jan 2021

Defined the vision and direction for IAG's Chroma design system, ensuring accessibility, consistency and scalability across digital products.

Key responsibilities

- Led design system strategy, architecture and direction.
- Embedded accessibility into reusable components, patterns and design system practices.
- Translated accessibility requirements into scalable solutions that could be reused across products and teams.
- Worked with designers and developers to make complex interface patterns accessible.
- Supported consistent implementation of accessible UI patterns across product teams.
- Developed component standards, documentation and contribution approaches.
- Supported accessible design-to-code workflows.
- Helped ensure accessibility decisions made at component level improved outcomes across multiple products.

UX Designer / UI Developer: Ambiat

Dec 2015 – Mar 2018

Developed a design system and component library for new web applications, combining UX, front-end development and accessibility.

Key responsibilities

- Responsible for the accessibility of web interfaces, including design system components, UI patterns and application layouts.
- Developed HTML and SCSS pattern libraries.
- Designed user interfaces and digital experiences.
- Integrated accessibility requirements throughout design and development.
- Developed reusable, accessible components and interaction patterns.
- Worked directly with developers to resolve accessibility issues in application interfaces.

UX Designer / UI Developer: WhistleOut

Feb 2015 – Dec 2015

Built a responsive component and layout pattern library for WhistleOut's digital products, combining UI development, design systemisation and accessibility.

Key responsibilities

- Responsible for accessibility across web interfaces, including reusable components, UI patterns and responsive layouts.
- Developed HTML, CSS and LESS frameworks and pattern libraries.
- Built reusable components and layout patterns with accessibility requirements incorporated from the outset.
- Designed and implemented responsive user interfaces.
- Helped improve consistency, usability and accessibility across WhistleOut's websites.

UI Developer and Accessibility Specialist: Fiserv

2013 – 2014

Provided accessibility advice and implementation support across a large banking application.

Key responsibilities

- Provided accessibility guidance for UI component implementation.
- Worked directly with developers to resolve accessibility issues in complex banking interfaces.
- Supported teams in applying WCAG requirements to digital interfaces.
- Developed HTML and CSS pattern libraries aligned with accessibility standards.
- Translated accessibility requirements into practical front-end solutions.

UX/UI Designer and Accessibility Specialist: Australian Museum

Jan 1998 – Dec 2013

Led the design and development of museum websites and web applications, with a strong focus on accessibility, UX and front-end development.

Key responsibilities

- Designed and developed accessible websites and digital experiences.
- Applied accessibility and usability principles throughout design and development.
- Developed reusable front-end patterns and component libraries.
- Conducted usability research and testing, including research with people with disabilities.

- Combined UX, UI and technical accessibility across digital projects.

Web Manager — Australian Museum

Mar 2005 – Jan 2006

Managed museum web projects, supervising three full-time staff and several contractors.

UX/UI Designer and Accessibility Specialist: Max Design

Jan 1990 – Feb 2014

Founded and managed Max Design, a Sydney-based web development business specialising in accessibility, UX and UI design.

Clients included Sensis, Microsoft Australia, Sydney Morning Herald, Amnesty International Australia and Reed Publishing.

Key responsibilities

- Designed and developed accessible, standards-compliant websites.
- Provided accessibility, UX and front-end development services.
- Worked directly with developers and organisations to resolve accessibility and usability issues.
- Delivered training on HTML, CSS, web standards and accessibility from 2005 onwards.
- Delivered workshops in Australia and internationally, including Singapore, New Zealand and the United States.
- Published technical articles and resources explaining web standards and accessibility concepts for developers.
- Worked with organisations to improve the accessibility and usability of digital products.

Skills

Accessibility testing and remediation

- Extensive experience conducting accessibility reviews, audits and assessments across digital products and web applications.
- Manual and automated testing against WCAG, including root-cause analysis and practical remediation guidance.
- Diagnose accessibility issues across semantics, forms, focus, keyboard interaction, accessible names, ARIA and complex interaction patterns.
- Work directly with developers and product teams to troubleshoot issues and implement practical solutions.

- Integrate accessibility into QA and development workflows through acceptance criteria, repeatable testing practices and automated testing pipelines.

Assistive technologies and accessibility testing

- Extensive experience testing with NVDA, JAWS and VoiceOver, alongside screen magnification, speech recognition and voice control technologies.
- Extensive keyboard-only and alternative input testing, supported by evaluation tools including Axe DevTools.
- Delivered practical NVDA and VoiceOver training for teams and accessibility practitioners.
- Test how HTML, ARIA and interface components are exposed across assistive technologies, browsers, devices and operating systems.
- Develop and maintain test cases and support documentation comparing accessibility behaviour across browser and assistive technology combinations.
- Deep understanding of browser accessibility trees, operating system accessibility APIs and the interaction between browsers, platforms and assistive technologies.

Accessibility strategy, governance and compliance

- Develop accessibility strategies that build capability across organisational teams.
- Develop pre-training engagement and post-training follow-up approaches to support sustained accessibility capability.
- Support accessibility governance by helping organisations define responsibilities, processes and expectations.
- Help teams embed accessibility acceptance criteria in design, development and QA.
- Advise organisations on practical approaches to governance, compliance, continuous improvement and shared ownership of accessibility.

Standards, legislation and guidance

- Extensive practical experience interpreting and applying WCAG across design, development, testing, remediation and training.
- Experience applying WCAG across large banking, insurance and other environments.
- Good working understanding of the Disability Discrimination Act 1992 and its relevance to digital accessibility.
- Familiar with AS EN 301 549 and its role in digital accessibility requirements.
- Familiar with Australian Human Rights Commission guidance.

Inclusive research with people with disabilities

- More than 20 years of experience conducting research and usability testing with people with disabilities, including sessions in participants' homes and workplaces.
- Conduct usability testing, interviews, focus groups, contextual inquiry, heuristic evaluation and moderated research with people with diverse disabilities and access needs.
- Conducted large-scale accessibility research with screen reader and Braille users, including research into data table accessibility.
- Adapt research methods, environments and communication approaches for different access needs and assistive technologies.
- Design and deliver training that helps researchers and product teams conduct inclusive, respectful and effective research with people with disability.

Training and capability development

- More than 20 years delivering technical and accessibility training across HTML, CSS, web standards, inclusive design, accessibility testing and assistive technologies.
- Delivered approximately 120 accessibility training courses during my first year at Intopia.
- Extensive experience delivering workshops and practical training in Australia and internationally, including Singapore, New Zealand and the United States.
- Deliver specialist training for developers, designers, testers, content creators and accessibility practitioners, including NVDA, VoiceOver and inclusive research.
- Translate WCAG, HTML, ARIA and complex accessibility concepts into practical guidance and hands-on learning for digital teams.

Technical accessibility and front-end development

- Extensive experience working directly with developers to make complex digital interfaces accessible, including large-scale banking and insurance products.
- Deep knowledge of semantic HTML, CSS, ARIA, native browser behaviour and accessible component architecture.
- Diagnose complex accessibility issues involving markup, browser behaviour, accessibility APIs and assistive technologies.
- Translate accessibility requirements into practical implementation guidance and support developers in troubleshooting solutions across browsers, devices and assistive technologies.
- More than 20 years writing articles, technical guidance and educational resources that explain complex accessibility and front-end concepts for developers.
- Develop and maintain online test cases, support reports and technical resources that investigate and document HTML, ARIA and assistive technology behaviour.